has run into a wall of opposition from within the alliance. Former minister Bacchu Kadu of Mahayuti ally Prahar Janshakti Party has fielded Dinesh Boob against the official candidate. The Shinde Sena leaders are said to be helping Kadu since they are at odds with Rana and her independent MLA husband Ravi Rana. So deep is the rivalry that the contest is being dubbed "Ranas versus the rest". Balwant Wankhede, in the fray for the Congress, has the odd fortune of being a bemused observer.

An equally interesting battle is brewing in Pawar pocket borough Baramati, framing the split in the NCP around its very nucleus. Sunetra Pawar, wife of deputy CM and breakaway chieftain Ajit Pawar, is locked in a prestige battle with sister-in-law Supriya Sule, old supremo and head of the residuary faction Sharad Pawar. Rebelling against Sunetra's candidature, Vijay Shivtare of the Shinde Sena had threatened to contest as an Independent, but has since been placated by Shinde, Ajit and the other deputy CM, Devendra Fadnavis. The latter has also had to soothe local BJP satrap and former minister Harshavardhan Patil, a long-time Ajit foe. Though the Shivtare-Patil duo will campaign for the NCP, the fracas has made for bad optics.

Infighting may also blight the Mahayuti's chances in Raigad, where Ajit faction MP Sunil Tatkare has been at odds with leaders of the BJP and Shinde Sena. A BJP MLA opposed to the Ajit faction wangling the ticket claims he will "put in an effort, but it will be 70 per cent, not 100 per cent".

Shinde's partymen admit to being upset with what they consider the BJP's "big brother" attitude and its stealing a march over them in seat-sharing along with the Ajit faction. The Shinde Sena has had to give up its claim on seats like Parbhani and Osmanabad, which the undivided party had won in 2019, for the Ajit faction. BJP and Ajit group leaders are also staking claim on Sena strongholds like Nashik, Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar (Aurangabad) and Thane. The BJP also wants Palghar, a seat it had conceded to the Sena in 2019.



COMMON CAUSE (L-R) MVA leaders Nana Patole, Uddhav Thackeray, Sharad Pawar, Prithviraj Chavan and Balasaheb Thorat in Mumbai, Apr. 9

ANI

Not even Shinde's home turf Thane is immune to this tug-of-war. Incumbent MP Rajan Vichare is with the Sena (UBT). Incidentally, Shinde has yet to formally declare the nomination of his son Dr Shrikant, a two-term MP from Kalyan, perhaps to sustain the suspense on where Shrikant will contest from—Kalyan or Thane. But Fadnavis went ahead and announced his name for the Kalyan seat anyway.

An Ajit faction leader admits that the seat-sharing delay has hurt the Mahayuti. "We held a joint rally in Thane where our leaders made speeches claiming that Prime Minister Narendra Modi was our candidate and called on voters to get us 45 seats in Maharashtra and over 400 across the country," he says. As a Shinde Sena leader from Thane district confesses, opposition to them in some areas comes from the BJP and vice versa. The inclusion of the Ajit faction of the NCP does not help.

The Shinde Sena's apprehensions go beyond the LS polls. The MLAs who left with Shinde feel the BJP will stake a claim to their seats in the assembly polls later this year. While acting as the big brother, says one MP, "it expects the younger brother to make the sacrifices." Another MP says "alliance dharma" is forcing them to ensure a lead for BJP-NCP candidates from their strongholds. Else they could be denied renomination in the assembly polls or be on a weak wicket at the hustings.

THE SHINDE SENA CANDIDATES ARE UPSET AT WHAT THEY CONSIDER THE BJP'S BIG BROTHER ATTITUDE AND HAVING TO CEDE STRONGHOLDS TO THE BJP AND THE NCP

An Ajit faction candidate is candid about the less-than-grand state of the grand alliance. It won a convert in Archana Patil, wife of BJP MLA Rana Jagjitsinh Patil, and nominated her as its candidate from Dharashiv (Os-